

staffing services, data-com testing tools, development and automation. "If a candidate goes in for a certification, he is a nose ahead over others in terms of employability in the industry. The companies prefer such candidates, as they require less moulding before assigning them a project. Moreover, most service-based MNCs in India prefer certification, as they can claim the employees they are outsourcing are certified, and this adds credibility," Sajith adds.

Sumit Gandhi has been working at Greycells18 Media for a little over nine months as a junior software developer in PHP programming. He feels that his certification played a major role in landing him a job. Gandhi shares, "At most interviews I attended, one of the most repeated enquiries related to RHCE certification. The interviewers asked me questions about development and scripting. As a fresher, they tested me for my depth of knowledge, and I was able to answer all the questions asked. They also asked me to write a shell script program. Employers tend to consider you as a serious candidate as they feel you are proficient on Linux. By opting for a certification, I feel like I increased my chances—not just by being certified, but the certification course gave me a lot of in-depth knowledge about the subject."

Apart from acting as a reasonable indicator of knowledge, certification also helps candidates stand out during interviews. "When prominent organisations post their vacancies on job sites, thousands of applications come pouring in. If it weren't for certification, the company would have to spend a lot of time going through their details and evaluating their expertise," feels Varad Gupta, CTO, Keen & Able Computers, an open source systems integration, solutions and consultancy company. "Certifications may not guarantee a job to candidates, but it helps to at least land them an interview. For experienced candidates, the need for certification depends on which area they plan to build a career in. If there are certifications in the candidate's area of interest, there is no doubt that such certification would help. I have seen cases of two equally skilled employees interviewing for the same job, and the one with the certification held the advantage and bagged the position. Certifications also help when reasonably skilled people want to move up in their organisation," Gupta adds.

Certification must be backed by the right skills and experience

Menon believes that an open source enthusiast takes up a Linux certification course primarily from an employability perspective. He elaborates, "Once the candidates get a strong base in mainstream technology work, they can expand their knowledge in specialised domains like Perl, Python, Android scripting, etc., within the open source space, transforming them into core specialists and critical resources of the organisation. They would, in turn, contribute back strongly to



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Linux courses that the industry recommends:

- Red Hat Certifications: Red Hat Certified Engineer (RHCE), Red Hat Certified Virtualisation (RHCVS), Red Hat Certified System Administrator (RHCSA), Red Hat Certified Security Specialist
- Novell Certifications: Certified Linux Administrator, Novell Certified Linux Professional, Novell Certified Linux Engineer
- CompTIA Linux+
- IBM AIX
- Hewlett-Packard UniX (HP UX)
- Sun Solaris
- Oracle Certified Professional
- Zend certifications
- Linux Professional Institute (LPI)
- Offensive Security Certified Professional (OSCP)

the open source community." Dr Ram P Rustagi, professor, MCA Department, People's Educational Society Institute of Technology (PESIT), adds that it would help if a candidate gains proficiency in generic courses on Android internals/ applications development, Linux internals and device driver programming, shell scripting, PostgreSQL DB, PHP (Zend certifications), Perl and Ruby on Rails.

However, a certification cannot guarantee you a job, but only aid you by pointing you in the right direction. If you already have a strong base in your area of interest, a certification is merely a tag on your resume. "A certificate is like testing a candidate's performance," feels Saurabh Galav, founder and Red Hat trainer at Linux Scrappers, a Linux training institute. "Students can get the certification only with proper training, and if they have a strong knowledge base about the operating system. After choosing candidates with certification, the interviewers will later focus on how well a candidate knows the subject. They want to check what level of experience they have, and what type of problems they have solved. If they find that the candidate has somehow managed to get certified, but does not have enough knowledge about the subject or shows less interest, there goes his opportunity!" Galav quips. Sumit Kadian, a B-Tech graduate in IT who is currently searching for a job, couldn't agree more. He talks about his experience of attending interviews at organisations